Poem: **Sleep Without Wake**

Poet: **A.A. Amoako**

What is the poem about?

"Sleep Without Wake" is a poem that explores the grief associated with losing a mother and the breaking up of bonds between a mother and a son.

This article will highlight the poem, line by line explanation of the poem, themes, literary devices, mood, form and structure and some questions and answers.

The Poem

Sleep Without Wake

Mother's milk gave me suck
Mother's fingers soothed my skin
The night kept Mother awake
When baby was sour
And that was me!

You vanished into the morning mist of
April's last days, 1998

Precisely how and when is

Locked up in your wooden box

Thus severing the Korlebu cord between

You and me, Premier son of a Premier daughter

Abenaa's Pioneer child Kwabena

You put me through my infant paces

On Gold Coast's Ga Shikp]n

Taa Taa, tuu tuu, in your maternal steps,

Maame Tutuaa, condolences!

You were brought into view again after

A long chilling month, your face frozen

Into a grim Visage

Till you thawed somewhat

Into your familiar self but,

Still, inert, immobile like a

Sculptured bride

To the Mourners' wailful gaze

Your last Odumase words to me

Only a week before were,

Go in peace, it looks like rain"

Words as auspicious, puzzling, portentous,

Looking back.

Line by Line explanation

Mother's milk gave me suck

Children love their mother's breast milk. This line shows that the narrator depended on his mother's breast milk for sustenance.

Mother's fingers soothed my skin

This line explains the comfort and care provided by the mother, with the gentle touch of her finger soothing the narrator.

It relieves him from his pains in times of sickness.

The night kept Mother awake

When baby was sour

The "Night" represents the struggle and stress the narrator's mother went through during difficult times with her baby. The baby becomes sour when he's not feeling well or in discomfort.

And that was me!

The narrator refers to himself and lets the reader know that he is the baby in the poem.

You vanished into the morning mist of

April's last days, 1998

The narrator reveals the exact date he lost his mother.

He describes the disappearance of his mother, using metaphorical language like "morning mist" to show a sense of mystery and sudden separation.

Precisely how and when is

Locked up in your wooden box

These lines tell the reader that the narrator does not know the cause and time of his mother's death.

This secret is kept in her wooden box(casket or coffin). She is the only person with this knowledge.

Thus severing the Korlebu cord between

You and me,

Korlebu is a well-known hospital in Accra. The poet uses the Korlebu cord to show the final separation between himself and his mother.

Thus the umbilical cord which tied him to her mother at birth is finally cut off.

Premier son of a Premier daughter

Abenaa's Pioneer child Kwabena

The narrator shows the reader another connection he shares with his mother. The poet is the first son of his mother and his mother in turn is the first daughter of her mother. Such is a special thing they share together.

Kwabena is the name given to the poet. The name Kwabena is an Akan name for a male born on Tuesday.

You put me through my infant paces On Gold Coast's Ga

Shikp]n

Learning how to walk is a major event in the life of a young child. The persona's mother was there to support her child to take his first steps.

Taa Taa, tuu tuu, in your maternal steps,Maame Tutuaa, condolences!

Taa taa and **tuu tuu** is a playful language used by parents to encourage children to learn how to walk.

This line also reveals the name of Kwabena's mother which is Maame Tutuaa.

You were brought into view again after

A long chilling month, your face frozen into a grim Visage

"A long chilling month" depicts one month at the morgue. His mother had changed from her natural state to an unattractive and sorrowful state due to the preservation of her body.

Till you thawed somewhat
Into your familiar self but,
Still, insert, immobile

Her body changed from a solid state to a soft state. After the ice had melted away, she still couldn't move.

like a Sculptured bride

To the Mourners' wailful gaze

The poet compares the image of her mother to a sculptured bride. The sad appearance of the lifeless body causes sympathisers to watch and cry.

Your last Odumase words to me

Only a week before were,

The last conversation the narrator had with his mother was at Odumase before her mother's demise.

Go in peace, it looks like rain"

Did Maame Tutuaa know about her own demise? What made her say those words? These words sound like a warning to what is about to happen.

Words as auspicious, puzzling, portentous,

Looking back.

The narrator had difficulty in understanding her last words to him. The words seem to have a hidden meaning which would be revealed later.

Themes in the Poem

- **The grief associated with losing a parent:** The narrator mourns his mother because of the undying love and affection he received from her.
- **The bond between a son and a mother**: The poet shows many instances of bonding through shared memories and parental guidance.
- **The struggles and stress of being a parent:** It is not easy being a parent. Parenting has its own problems such as lack of sleep, worry, anxiety etc. The poem highlights some of these points.

Literary Devices

PERSONIFICATION

- The night kept Mother awake

EUPHEMISM

- Sleep without wake.
- Wooden box: it means a coffin.
- You vanished into the morning mist of April.
- Thus severing the Korlebu chord between you and me.

ALLITERATION

- Mother's milk gave me suck
- Your face frozen into a grim visage

REPETITION

- Premier son of a Premierdaughter

ASSONANCE

- Taa taa tuu tuu in your maternal steps.

ONOMATOPOEIA

- Taa taa tuu tuu, in your maternal steps.

SIMILE

- Still, inert, immobile like a sculptured bride.
- "Go in peace, It looks like rain"

Mood

- Sorrow
- Regret
- Separation
- sympathy

Form and Structure

- The poem has uneven lines with no end rhymes.

- It uses flowing sentences, where one line connects to the next. This makes it feel like a continuous story.
- The poem unfolds as a narrative journey.
- It uses metaphor and imagery to blend themes of maternal love and separation.

Questions and Answers on Sleep without Wake

1. Kwabena lost his mother in which year?

ANS: **1998**

2. Into a grim Visage(line 19)means....

ANS: **Unattractive face.**

3.Identify two lines which describes mother as caring and gentle.

ANS:

- **You put me through my infant paces**
- **Mother's finger soothed my skin**

4. Mention two themes of this poem.

ANS:

1. **The undying love between parents and their children.**
2. **The pain and agony of losing a loved one.**

5. What happened in April's last days, 1998?

ANS: **Kwabena lost his mother**

6. How long ago, and where, did mother say,"Go in peace, it looks like rain"(line7)

ANS**: A week before her demise at Odumase.**

7. The phrase: *Premier son of a Premier daughter*(line 11) refers to whom?

ANS: **The narrator (Kwabena)**

8. What is described in the poem as: *Still, inert, immobile like a sculptured bride?*

ANS: **Kwabena's mother's dead body.**

9. Name two literary devices found in line(15) *Taa taa, tuu tuu, in your maternal steps.*

ANS: **1. Onomatopoeia**

. **2. Alliteration**

10. What is said to be…..Words as auspicious, puzzling, portentous,(line28)

ANS: **Kwabena's mother's last words to her son**.("Go in peace, it looks like rain")

11. Where did mother vanish into?

ANS: **She vanished into the morning mist**

12. The poem *Sleep without wake* is about whom?

ANS: **Maame Tutuaa**

13. Sleep without wake as the title of the poem is an example of which literary device?

ANS: **Euphemism**